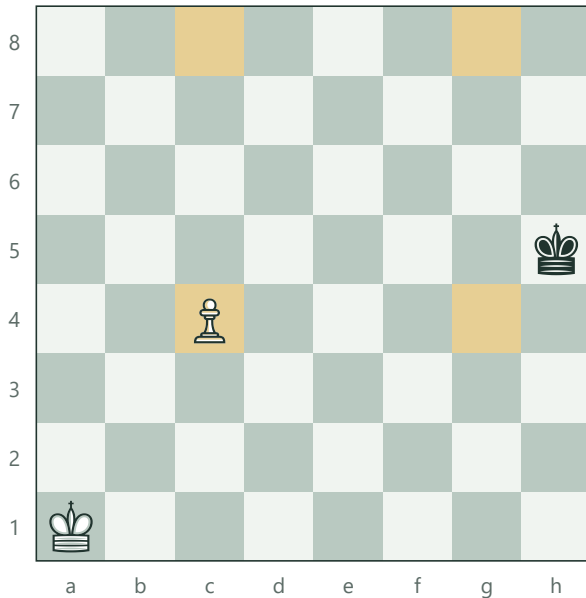


Activate the king; count the race

With fewer pieces, kings can become active helpers. Before marching a king forward, make sure checks and mating threats are under control.



White to move. Can the c-pawn promote?

The square of the pawn

The c4-pawn needs four moves to reach c8. Its catch square extends from c4 to g4, g8, and c8.

Who moves matters

Black's king on h5 is outside. After White plays c5, Black cannot enter the smaller catch square in time.

An illustrative race

1.c5 Kg5 2.c6 Kf6 3.c7 Ke7 4.c8=Q. White promotes safely.

Change the turn and test again

If Black moves first, the king can enter the square: 1...Kg5 2.c5 Kf6 3.c6 Ke7 4.c7 Kd7 5.c8=Q Kxc8. The distant white king cannot help. The same placement of pieces can therefore have a different result depending on the turn.

Know when the shortcut applies

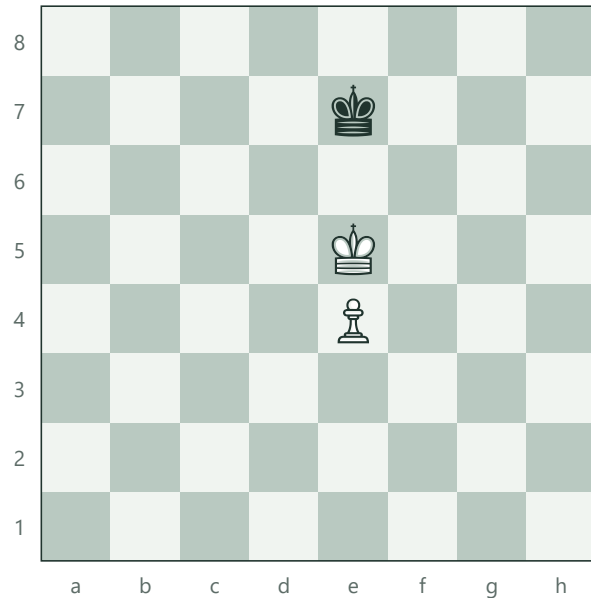
The square is a shortcut for an unobstructed race between a pawn and a king. Other pieces, a supporting king, blocked paths, or checks require calculation. Account for a pawn's initial two-square move when relevant.

ENDGAME CHECKLIST

Activate the king, identify passed pawns, count promotion moves, and check whose promotion gives check. A passed pawn has no enemy pawn ahead of it on its own or neighboring files.

Opposition wins access to squares

In direct opposition, the kings face each other with one square between them. The side that need not move its king can restrict the other king.



Black to move. White has the opposition.

The barrier

The kings on e5 and e7 deny each other entry to the squares between them.

Make room for the king

After 1...Kd7, White can play 2.Kf6. After 1...Kf7, White can play 2.Kd6.

The purpose

White uses the king to gain space in front of the e4-pawn, rather than pushing the pawn without support.

Use the king before the pawn

In many king-and-pawn endings, the king must first gain the squares that let the pawn advance safely. A pawn move can spend a valuable spare tempo or make the defender's job easier. Check the position before automatically pushing.

Opposition is a tool, not a verdict

The pawn's file and rank, spare pawn moves, and the available routes matter. Rook pawns near a corner have special drawing possibilities. Do not label an ending won merely because your king currently has the opposition.

PRACTICE BOTH ROLES

Play this position with Black to move. Then reset it with White to move and notice how the choices change. Use an endgame trainer to check your play, and explain which squares each king is trying to control.

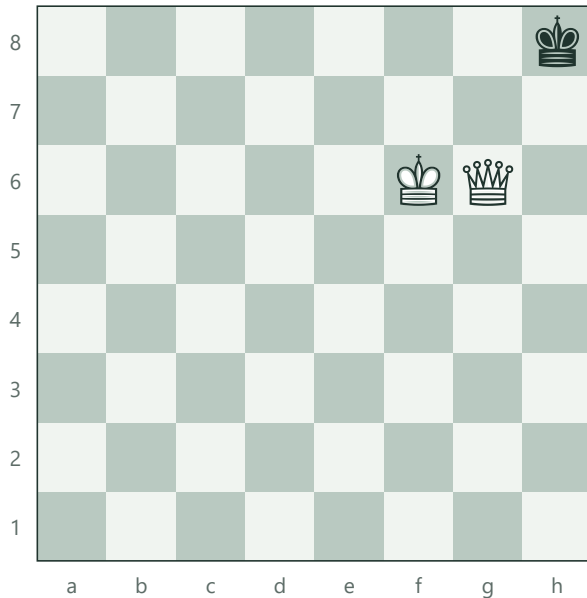
LEARN AND PRACTICE

Opposition - Chess.com

Interactive tactics, checkmates, and endgames - lichess.org/practice

Finish cleanly and respect the draw

A large material advantage still needs accurate technique. King activity, rook activity, and stalemate awareness are practical essentials.



The king is not in check

White's queen on g6 does not attack h8.

There is no legal escape

The queen controls g8, g7, and h7. Black has no other piece to move.

Before your quiet move

When the opponent has very little material, check whether the move leaves them a legal reply.

Black to move: stalemate, so the game is drawn.

Basic mating technique

With king and queen, restrict the lone king, bring your king closer, and deliver a supported mate near an edge. With king and rook, coordinate both pieces to cut off ranks or files. Practice the full technique.

Rook endings: prefer useful activity

An active rook can check, attack pawns, and cut off the king. A rook behind a passed pawn is often useful; check the tactics. Practice the Lucena winning method and the Philidor defensive setup.

DRAWS TO RECOGNIZE

Stalemate: the player to move has no legal move and is not in check. Repetition and move-count draws also exist. Under FIDE rules, threefold repetition and 50 moves by each side without a pawn move or capture generally require a correct claim; fivefold repetition and 75 such moves are automatic. Checkmate on the final move takes precedence over the 75-move rule.

PRACTICE AND RULE REFERENCES: ARTICLES 5.2 AND 9

Basic rook endgames: Lucena and Philidor - Lichess

FIDE Laws of Chess - handbook.fide.com/chapter/e012023